PRESS RELEASE

Former Tulare County Medical Doctor Pleads Guilty to Distributing Misbranded Drugs Using False Claims about COVID-19

Monday, May 19, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Eastern District of California

Stephen D. Meis, M.D., 73, formerly of Visalia, pleaded guilty today to one count of introduction of misbranded drugs into interstate commerce, Acting U.S. Attorney Michele Beckwith announced.

According to court documents, Meis was the Medical Director of Golden Sunrise Pharmaceutical Inc. and Golden Sunrise Nutraceutical Inc. that manufactured, marketed, and sold products claiming to effectively treat a variety of medical conditions.

Beginning on March 30, 2020, Meis and Golden Sunrise's Chief Executive Officer Huu Tieu, 62, of Porterville, began selling a set of herbal mixtures they called the "Emergency D-Virus Plan of Care" as a COVID-19 treatment. The treatment consisted of a box containing various vials of Golden Sunrise drug products, including one called "Imunstem," together with an "Emergency D-Virus Plan of Care" information sheet. Meis and Tieu mailed the products to various practitioners, public officials, and other individuals both inside and outside of California.

The labeling for the drugs, including the information sheet that accompanied the drugs, was false and misleading and stated that ImunStem and other Golden Sunrise products were "uniquely qualified to treat and modify the course of the virus epidemic in China and other countries." Golden Sunrise falsely claimed the products had been the first dietary supplement in the United States to be approved as a prescription medicine by the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) to treat the COVID-19 virus. In fact, the drugs were not FDA approved, and no Golden Sunrise product had ever been approved by the FDA for any purpose.

On June 12, 2024, Tieu was sentenced to 18 months in prison for introduction of misbranded drugs into interstate commerce.

This case is the product of an investigation by the FDA Office of Criminal Investigations, the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services Office of Inspector General, and the Federal Bureau of Investigation with assistance from the Tulare County District Attorney's Office. Assistant U.S. Attorneys Jeffrey A. Spivak and Emilia P.E. Morris are prosecuting the case.

Meis is scheduled to be sentenced by U.S. District Judge Jennifer L. Thurston on July 14, 2025. Meis faces a maximum statutory penalty of 12 months in prison and a $100,000 fine. The actual sentence, however, will be determined at the discretion of the court after consideration of any applicable statutory factors and the Federal Sentencing Guidelines, which take into account a number of variables.

Updated May 19, 2025

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